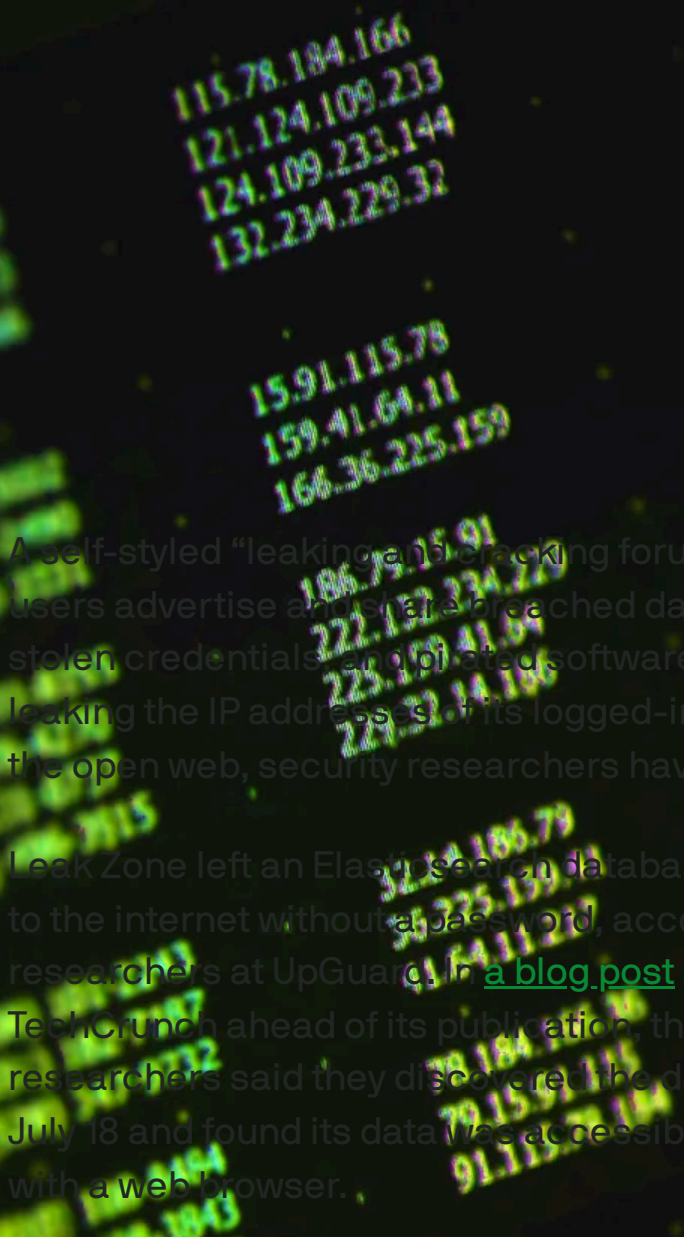


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SECURITY



Cybercrime forum Leak Zone publicly exposed its users' IP addresses



A self-styled “leaking and cracking forum” where users advertise and share breached databases, stolen credentials, and pirated software was leaking the IP addresses of its logged-in users to the open web, security researchers have found.

Leak Zone left an Elasticsearch database exposed to the internet without a password, according to researchers at UpGuard. In [a blog post](#) shared with TechCrunch ahead of its publication, the researchers said they discovered the database on July 18 and found its data was accessible to anyone with a web browser.

The exposed database contained more than 22 million records storing the IP address and precise timestamp of when Leak Zone users logged in. The records were dated as recently as June 25, and the database was updating in real time.

While the records were not linked to individual users, the data could be used to identify users who logged into Leak Zone without using any anonymization tools. Some of the records, seen by TechCrunch, indicate whether a user is believed to have logged in through [a proxy](#), such as [a VPN](#), which can help conceal the user’s real-world location.

Leak Zone, which gained popularity in 2020, advertises access to a “vast collection of leaks ranging from breached databases to cracked

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accounts,” referring to stolen credentials used for logging into a person’s online accounts. The forum also offers a marketplace that explicitly promotes “illegal services,” the site’s guide reads. A page on Leak Zone’s website claims the forum has more than 109,000 users.

According to UpGuard, 95% of the records in the exposed database relate to Leak Zone user logins. The remaining data references accounts associated with AccountBot, another site for selling access to compromised accounts used for streaming services.

TechCrunch verified that the exposed database was recording users logging into Leak Zone by creating a new account and logging in to the site. A corresponding record immediately appeared in the exposed database containing our IP address and the timestamp of the exact moment we logged in.

It’s not known why the database was publicly exposed. Human error or misconfigurations are often a cause of data exposures, rather than malicious actions.

TechCrunch was unable to contact the Leak Zone administrators for comment as the forum software denied our ability to send them messages. It’s not clear if the Leak Zone administrators are aware of the exposure or if they plan to notify their users about the security lapse.

The database is no longer online, UpGuard told TechCrunch.

In recent years, U.S. and international authorities have increasingly [targeted cybercrime forums](#) and websites for their [roles in facilitating hacking, identity theft, and other criminal activity](#). This week, Europol announced it had [arrested the alleged administrator](#) behind XSS.is, a long-running

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Russian-language cybercrime forum, which the authorities also seized as part of a takedown operation.

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Zack Whittaker

Security Editor |

Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at...

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SECURITY



A leaky database spilled
2FA codes for the world's
tech giants

A technology company that routes millions of SMS text messages across the world has secured an exposed database that was spilling one-time security codes that may have granted users' access to their Facebook, Google and TikTok accounts.

The Asian technology and internet company YX International manufactures cellular networking equipment and provides SMS text message routing services. SMS routing helps to get time-critical text messages to their proper destination across various regional cell networks and providers, such as [a user receiving an SMS security code or link for logging in to online services](#).

YX International claims to send [5 million SMS text messages daily](#).

But the technology company left one of its internal databases exposed to the internet without a password, allowing anyone to access the sensitive

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users, including one-time passcodes and password reset links for some of the world's largest tech and online companies, including Facebook and WhatsApp, Google, TikTok, and others.

The database had monthly logs dating back to July 2023 and was growing in size by the minute.

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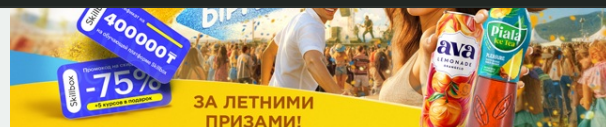
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[Two-factor authentication \(2FA\) offers greater protection against online account hijacks](#) that rely on password theft by sending an additional code to a trusted device, such as someone's phone. Two-factor codes and password resets, like the ones found in the exposed database, typically expire after a few minutes or once they are used.

But codes sent over SMS text messages are not as secure as stronger forms of 2FA — an app-based code generator, for example — since SMS text messages are [prone to interception or exposure](#), or in this case, leaking from a database onto the open web.

In the exposed database, TechCrunch found sets of internal email addresses and corresponding passwords associated with YX International, and alerted the company to the spilling database. The database went offline a short time later. A representative for YX International, who did not provide their name, responded soon after saying the company “sealed this vulnerability.”

When asked by TechCrunch, the YX International representative said that the server did not store access logs, which would have determined if anyone other than Sen discovered the exposed database and its contents.

YX International would not say for how long the database was exposed.

When reached by email, a Meta spokesperson did not comment. Spokespeople for Google and TikTok did not respond to requests for comment.

23andMe data theft prompts DNA testing companies to switch on 2FA by default



DNA testing and genealogy companies are stepping up user account security by mandating the use of two-factor authentication, following the theft of millions of user records from DNA genetic testing giant 23andMe. Ancestry, MyHeritage and 23andMe have begun notifying customers that their accounts will use two-factor (2FA) by default, a security feature where users are ...

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Zack Whittaker
Security Editor |

Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at...

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AngelSense exposed location data and personal information of tracked users

Zack Whittaker — 1:30 PM PST · January 30, 2025



AngelSense, an assistive technology company that provides location monitoring devices for people with disabilities, was spilling the personally identifiable information and precise location data of its users to the open internet, TechCrunch has learned.

The company secured the exposed server on Monday, more than a week after it was alerted to the data leak by researchers at security firm UpGuard.

UpGuard shared details of the exposure exclusively with TechCrunch after AngelSense resolved the lapse. UpGuard has [since published a blog post](#) on the incident.

The New Jersey-based AngelSense provides GPS trackers and location monitoring to thousands of customers, according [to its mobile app listing](#), and is touted by law enforcement and police departments across the United States.

According to UpGuard's researchers, AngelSense left an internal database exposed to the internet without a password, allowing anyone to access the

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Amanda Silberling,
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data inside using only a web browser and knowledge of the database's public IP address. The database was storing real-time updating logs from an AngelSense system, which included the personal information of AngelSense customers, as well as technical logs about the company's systems.

UpGuard said it found customers' personal data, like names, postal addresses, and phone numbers in the exposed database. The researchers said they also found GPS coordinates of individuals being monitored — including associated health information about the tracked person, which included conditions like autism and dementia. The researchers also found email addresses, passwords, and authentication tokens for accessing customer accounts, as well as partial credit card information — all of which was visible in plaintext, UpGuard said.

It's not known exactly how long the database was exposed nor how many customers were affected. According to the database's listing on Shodan, a search engine of internet-facing devices and systems, AngelSense's exposed logging database was first spotted online on January 14, though it may have been exposed some time earlier.

AngelSense chief executive Doron Somer confirmed to TechCrunch that the company took the exposed server offline after initially identifying UpGuard's first email as spam.

"It was only when UpGuard phoned us that the issue was raised to our attention," Somer said. "Upon its discovery, we acted promptly to validate the information provided to us and to remedy the vulnerability."

"We note that other than UpGuard, we have no information suggesting that any data on the logging

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system potentially was accessed. Nor do we have any evidence or indication that the data has been misused or is under threat of misuse,” Somer told TechCrunch, claiming that the data “was not sensitive personal information.”

Somer would not say if the company has the technical means to determine if there was any access to the unprotected server prior to UpGuard’s discovery.

When asked if the company planned to notify affected customers and individuals whose data was exposed, Somer said the company was still investigating.

“If notice to regulators or persons is warranted, we will of course provide it,” Somer said.

Somer did not respond to a follow-up inquiry by press time.

Database exposures are often the result of misconfigurations caused by human error, rather than malicious intent, and have become an increasingly common occurrence in recent years. Similar security lapses of exposed databases have resulted in the [spill of sensitive U.S. military emails](#), the real-time leak of text messages [containing two-factor codes](#), and [chat histories from AI chatbots](#).

Topics: [AngelSense](#) [cybersecurity](#) [data exposure](#)

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Zack Whittaker

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